

Warehouse Safety Procedure

Document reference WSP-2024-03. Issued by the site safety officer, Northfield Distribution Centre. This procedure applies to all employees, agency staff, contractors and visitors entering the operational area. It supersedes all previous versions, including WSP-2022-01, and must be reviewed annually.

1. Purpose and scope

The purpose of this procedure is to set out the minimum safety requirements for working in the distribution centre, and to make clear who is accountable for enforcing each of them. It is written to be read by people doing the work, not only by managers, and every requirement in it is intended to be checkable on the floor.

This procedure covers the goods-in bay, the racking aisles, the pick faces, the cold storage area, the baling and waste compaction area, the battery charging bay and the loading dock. It does not cover the office block or the staff canteen, which are governed by the general workplace policy, nor the yard beyond the dock apron, which is covered by the vehicle movement plan.

Where this procedure conflicts with a customer instruction or a supplier's handling recommendation, this procedure takes precedence. Any conflict must be reported to the site safety officer, who is responsible for resolving it in writing before the affected work continues.

2. Responsibilities

Shift supervisors are responsible for confirming that every person on the floor has completed induction training before the shift begins, that the daily equipment checks have been recorded, and that any defect raised during those checks has either been rectified or the equipment removed from service.

Team members are responsible for using the protective equipment issued to them, for reporting defects and near misses, and for stopping work if they believe a task cannot be completed safely. No person will face disciplinary action for stopping work on genuine safety grounds.

The site safety officer is responsible for maintaining this procedure, for investigating reportable incidents, and for auditing compliance at least quarterly. Audit findings are circulated to all supervisors within five working days.

3. Definitions

Operational area means any part of the site where goods are moved, stored or handled, including the dock apron up to the yellow boundary line. Powered industrial truck means any counterbalance forklift, reach truck, low level order picker or powered pallet truck in use on site.

Near miss means an event that had the potential to cause injury or damage but did not do so. Reportable incident means any event resulting in injury requiring more than first aid, damage to racking or building structure, or any spill of a hazardous substance.

Competent person means an individual who holds current certification for the task in question and whose certification has been verified by the shift supervisor against the training register.

4. Induction and access control

No person may enter the operational area without completing site induction. Induction covers the layout of the building, the traffic routes, the alarm tones, the assembly points and the contents of this procedure. It is valid for twelve months.

Access is controlled by badge at the personnel door adjacent to the goods-in bay. Badges are not transferable. Any person who has lost a badge must report to the shift supervisor and will be escorted until a replacement is issued.

Visitors must sign in at reception, be issued a visitor badge and a high-visibility vest, and remain with their host at all times. A host may escort no more than four visitors at once. Visitors are not permitted in the cold storage area, the battery charging bay or the baling area under any circumstances.

Agency staff are inducted on their first shift and are marked with a green vest for their first ten shifts, so that experienced staff can identify them and offer support. The green vest does not replace the high-visibility requirement; it is issued in place of the standard vest and meets the same specification.

5. General personal protective equipment

High-visibility vests to EN ISO 20471 Class 2 or above must be worn at all times in the racking aisles, the goods-in bay and the loading dock. Vests must be fastened. A vest that is torn, heavily soiled or no longer reflective must be exchanged at the stores counter, which holds replacement stock on every shift.

Steel toe-capped safety boots to EN ISO 20345 S3 are mandatory anywhere pallets are moved or stored. Trainers, canvas shoes and safety footwear with exposed damage to the toe cap are not permitted. Staff are issued one pair on induction and may exchange them once every twelve months, or sooner if they are damaged in service.

Bump caps are required beneath racking where the clearance to the underside of the beam is less than two metres. The affected aisles are marked with blue floor tape and signage at both ends. Bump caps are not a substitute for a safety helmet and must not be worn where a helmet is specified.

Hearing protection is required within ten metres of the baling compactor while it is running, and within the battery charging bay while forced ventilation is active. The compactor operator must confirm the area is clear before starting a cycle and must not leave the machine unattended mid-cycle.

Cut-resistant gloves to EN 388 level B or above must be worn when opening cartons with a knife, when handling banding, and when breaking down damaged pallets. Gloves must not be worn when operating a powered industrial truck, because they reduce control feedback through the steering and hydraulic controls.

Eye protection is required when using compressed air, when decanting any hazardous substance, and when working beneath the sprinkler system during maintenance. Prescription safety glasses are available on request through the site safety officer.

6. Powered industrial trucks

Only staff holding a current counterbalance or reach truck licence appropriate to the machine may operate it. Licences are verified against the training register at the start of each shift and expire after three years. An expired licence is treated as no licence.

A pre-use check must be completed and recorded before the first use of a truck on each shift. The check covers forks and carriage, mast chains, hydraulic hoses, tyres, horn, lights, seat belt, and the condition and charge of the battery. Any defect that affects safe operation takes the truck out of service immediately; the key is surrendered to the shift supervisor and a defect tag is attached.

The maximum speed inside the building is 8 km/h, and 5 km/h within the goods-in bay and on the dock apron. Speed is monitored by telematics and reported weekly. Operators must sound the horn at every blind corner and at every pedestrian crossing point.

Seat belts must be worn whenever the truck is in motion. Forks must be lowered to within 150 millimetres of the floor and tilted back when travelling. Travelling with the load elevated is prohibited without exception, including over short distances within a single aisle.

No person may ride on a truck, on the forks, or on a pallet raised by a truck. Where work at height is required, the mobile elevating work platform or the approved order picker cage must be used, and a second person must remain at floor level throughout.

Trucks must not be left unattended with the engine running or the key in place. When parked, forks are lowered fully to the floor, the parking brake is applied, and the key is returned to the key board at the supervisor's desk.

7. Pedestrian segregation and traffic management

Pedestrian walkways are marked in green and are separated from truck routes by physical barriers wherever the building layout allows. Where segregation is not physically possible, the shared route is marked in yellow hatching and is subject to a 5 km/h limit.

Pedestrians always have right of way. A powered industrial truck must come to a complete stop when a pedestrian is within three metres and must not proceed until the pedestrian has passed or has clearly signalled the operator to continue.

Pedestrians must not cross a truck route except at a marked crossing point. Crossing points are fitted with mirrors and, at the goods-in bay, with a pedestrian-activated warning light. Using a mobile telephone or wearing headphones while walking in the operational area is prohibited.

Reversing is permitted only where a forward manoeuvre is not practicable. Where a vehicle reverses onto the dock, the dock leveller interlock must be engaged and the traffic light system must show red to the driver before any loading begins.

8. Racking, palletising and load stability

Racking is inspected weekly by the shift supervisor and annually by an external competent person. Any beam or upright showing deformation, displacement or damage to the protective barrier must be reported immediately and the bay unloaded and barriered off until it has been assessed.

The safe working load for each bay is displayed on the upright at the end of every run. Loads must be placed centrally on the beams, with the pallet fully supported. Overhanging loads, damaged pallets and pallets with broken bottom boards must not be placed into racking.

Staff must not climb racking to retrieve stock under any circumstances, including where the item appears to be within easy reach. Where stock cannot be reached from the floor, a truck or the order picker must be used.

9. Cold storage area

The cold storage area operates at minus 18 degrees Celsius and is accessed through the airlock adjacent to pick face 40. Entry is restricted to staff who have completed the cold storage module of induction, which is refreshed every twelve months.

Required PPE in the cold storage area is an insulated freezer jacket, insulated gloves, thermal trousers and non-slip boots rated for sub-zero surfaces. A high-visibility vest must be worn over the freezer jacket, and the hood must be up whenever the wearer is working below head height in the racking.

Freezer clothing is issued personally, is stored in the heated locker outside the airlock and must never be left inside the cold area between shifts. Damp clothing significantly reduces thermal protection and must be exchanged before entry.

No person may work alone inside cold storage. Entry is logged on the board at the airlock, showing name and time of entry, and the supervisor confirms the board is clear at the end of every shift.

Continuous time inside the area is limited to 45 minutes, followed by a minimum 15 minute warming break in the heated rest area. Where the task requires repeated entry, total exposure must not exceed three hours in any eight hour shift.

The internal door release and the emergency alarm must be tested at the start of every shift and the test recorded. If either fails, the area is closed until an engineer has attended. The area is fitted with a personal alarm pull cord at each aisle end and a strobe repeater outside the airlock.

Symptoms of cold stress include shivering that will not stop, numbness in the fingers, slurred speech and unusual clumsiness. Any person showing these symptoms must be removed to the heated rest area immediately and the shift supervisor informed.

10. Manual handling and lifting

The single-person lift limit is 23 kilograms at waist height, reducing to 10 kilograms where the load must be lifted above shoulder height or below knee height. Loads above the applicable limit require a two-person lift, a pallet truck or a lift assist device.

Before lifting, staff must assess the load for weight, stability and grip, confirm the route is clear, and confirm there is somewhere to set the load down. Where the weight is not marked, the load is treated as being above the limit until it has been tested by tilting one corner.

Twisting while carrying a load is the single most common cause of back injury recorded on this site. Staff must turn with their feet, keep the load close to the body, and avoid carrying loads that obstruct their view of the route ahead.

Lift assist devices are available at the goods-in bay and at pick faces 1 to 12. Their use is mandatory for any drum, any roll of banding stock, and any carton marked as a two-person lift by the supplier.

11. Hazardous substances and spill response

All hazardous substances held on site are listed in the COSHH register kept at the supervisor's desk, and each has an assessment that specifies the protective equipment required for handling it. No substance may be brought onto site without an assessment.

Decanting is permitted only in the ventilated store adjacent to the battery bay, using the designated equipment, and only by a competent person. Decanted containers must be labelled immediately with the substance name and hazard pictograms. Unlabelled containers are treated as unknown hazards and disposed of accordingly.

Spill kits are located at the goods-in bay, the battery charging bay and the ventilated store. In the event of a spill, staff must first prevent access to the area, then inform the shift supervisor, and only then attempt containment if trained and equipped to do so.

12. Fire prevention and evacuation

Aisles, fire exits, extinguisher points and sprinkler heads must be kept clear at all times. A minimum clearance of 500 millimetres must be maintained between the top of any stored load and the sprinkler heads. Stock must never be stored in a fire corridor, even temporarily during a peak period.

Battery charging generates hydrogen. The battery charging bay is fitted with forced ventilation which must be running whenever a charger is energised. Smoking, vaping and any source of ignition are prohibited within the bay and within five metres of its entrance.

On hearing the continuous alarm tone, all staff must stop work, make the immediate area safe if it is possible to do so within a few seconds, and leave the building by the nearest available exit. Powered industrial trucks are lowered and parked where they stand, provided they do not obstruct a route.

The primary assembly point is the marked area at the north end of the visitor car park. The secondary assembly point, used when wind direction makes the primary point unsuitable, is the loading area outside unit 14. Supervisors take a roll call from the badge access report and report to the incident controller.

No person may re-enter the building until the incident controller has given explicit permission. Silencing of the alarm is not permission to re-enter.

Fire marshals are identified by a white helmet and are listed on the noticeboard at the personnel door. At least two fire marshals must be on site during any shift; where this cannot be met, the shift supervisor must inform the site safety officer before the shift starts.

13. Incident reporting and investigation

All incidents, including near misses and damage-only events, must be reported to the shift supervisor before the end of the shift in which they occurred. Reporting a near miss is treated as a positive contribution and is recorded as such.

The supervisor records the incident in the site log within 24 hours, capturing what happened, who was involved, what equipment was in use and what immediate action was taken. The log entry is not the investigation; it is the trigger for one.

Any injury requiring more than first aid must additionally be reported to the site safety officer within one working day. The affected area must be isolated and left undisturbed until it has been inspected, unless leaving it undisturbed would create a further hazard.

Reportable incidents are investigated by the site safety officer within five working days, using the site's root cause method. The investigation identifies contributing factors rather than individual blame, and produces actions with named owners and target dates.

Investigation outcomes are shared at the following week's shift briefings, including where no action is required, so that staff can see that reports are acted on. Outstanding actions are reviewed monthly by the site management team.

14. Contractors and visitors

Contractors must produce a risk assessment and method statement before work begins, and the shift supervisor must countersign it. Hot work requires a permit issued by the site safety officer, valid for one shift only, with a one hour fire watch after work ceases.

Contractors working at height, in a confined space, or on the electrical distribution system require a separate permit in each case, and their competence must be verified against certification presented at reception.

15. Training and competence

Training records are held in the site training register and are reviewed monthly by the shift supervisors against the shift roster, so that a lapsed certification is identified before the person is next rostered onto the affected task.

Refresher training is required annually for manual handling, cold storage working and fire marshal duties, and every three years for powered industrial truck operation. Refresher training that has lapsed removes authorisation for the task until it is completed.

Toolbox talks are delivered at the start of each week and cover a single topic drawn from recent incidents, audit findings or seasonal risk. Attendance is recorded, and staff who miss a talk receive it before their next shift on the affected task.

Where a member of staff is observed working unsafely, the immediate response is to stop the task and coach. Repeated unsafe behaviour after coaching is escalated to the site management team, and is treated as a training gap unless the investigation shows otherwise.

16. Review

This procedure is reviewed every twelve months by the site safety officer, or immediately following any reportable incident, any change to the building layout, or the introduction of any new class of equipment.

Proposed changes are circulated to shift supervisors for comment for ten working days before they take effect, except where an immediate change is required to remove a serious risk. Where an immediate change is made, it is communicated at the next shift briefing and confirmed in writing within two working days.

The current version of this procedure is held by the site safety officer and published on the noticeboard at the personnel door. Printed copies are uncontrolled and must be checked against the published version before being relied on.